

YOUR BONUS GUIDE

5 Questions Every College Student Should Answer Before It's Too Late

Drawn from *The College Buffet* by Andrew Mangle, Ph.D.

A companion to your Mangle Metric score

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Thank you for completing the Mangle Metric. You now have a number. This guide gives you something the number alone can't — five reflective questions, pulled from my 2020 book *The College Buffet*, that get underneath the score and into the decisions that produced it.

Each question below maps to a specific dimension on your score report. Answer them honestly, in writing, and you'll know exactly where to start.

Question 1 — Have You Practiced Your Ballet?

CONNECTS TO: D1 — WORK EXPERIENCE & APPLIED PROOF

In The College Buffet, I describe a quiz I give students to assess "fit" between them, their major, and their future. One question cuts deeper than the rest: *What have you actually done in your major?* Internships, jobs, competitions, real projects — not classes, not GPA, not intentions.

I put it to students this way: if you majored in ballet, wouldn't you have practiced some ballet? If you majored in marketing, have you actually run a campaign? If you majored in finance, have you modeled anything real? The major tells an employer what you studied. It says nothing about what you can do — unless you can point to proof.

Write your answer: What is the single most concrete thing you have produced in your field — something with a measurable result you could show, not just describe?

If you struggled to answer, that gap is not a character flaw. It's a visible, fixable target. This is the highest-weighted dimension in the entire Mangle Metric — 25 of 100 points — for exactly this reason.

Question 2 — Would You Give Up a Punch Card With Six of Eight Punches?

CONNECTS TO: D2 — CAREER TRAJECTORY & STRATEGIC CLARITY

College works like a frequent-customer card. Each semester gets you closer to a diploma. The closer you get, the harder it becomes to walk away — even if the direction stopped making sense two years ago. I call this the punch card problem, and almost no student is immune to it.

The danger isn't finishing. It's finishing without ever stopping to ask whether the punches are taking you somewhere you actually want to go. Six punches in does not mean you know what you're punching toward.

Write your answer: Name one specific company or role you are actively targeting right now. Not a field. Not an industry. One name. What have you done in the last 90 days to get in front of someone there?

If you can't name one, you're punching the card without a destination. That's fixable — but only once you've admitted it.

Question 3 — Do You Need a Chef or a Cook?

CONNECTS TO: D5 — NETWORK & RELATIONSHIP CAPITAL

I describe two kinds of mentors in the College Buffet: the Chef, who designs the menu and carries real influence, and the Cook, who executes what's asked of them. Most students never meet a real Chef — they get assigned a Cook and call it networking.

I also use the metaphor of a Sherpa: someone who has climbed the mountain before and can carry weight on your behalf. A Sherpa is not someone who accepted your LinkedIn request. A Sherpa is someone who would take your call and say your name in a room you're not in.

Write your answer: List the names of 3 to 5 people with real influence in your target field who would take your call today. Be honest — a connection is not the same as a Sherpa.

If that list is short or empty, you're not alone — in the first cohort of students scored on the Mangle Metric, this was the most commonly missed dimension among students who otherwise looked strong on paper.

Question 4 — Why Would You Go Anywhere Else?

CONNECTS TO: D6 — MAJOR ROI & FIELD AWARENESS

In the book, I challenge the assumption that one program is objectively "the best" — pointing out that most of those claims trace back to marketing budgets, not outcomes. The deeper question for you isn't which program is best. It's whether you actually know what you're buying.

Most students can tell you what they're studying. Very few can tell you what it's worth — the median salary, the employment rate, the actual outlook for someone with their specific degree.

Write your answer: What is the median starting salary for your major, according to actual data — not a guess? What percentage of graduates in your field are employed within six months?

If you don't know, the Bureau of Labor Statistics ([bls.gov](https://www.bls.gov)) has the real number. Look it up today — not after graduation.

Question 5 — Is Your Stomach Rumbling, and Why?

CONNECTS TO: D7 — FINANCIAL SELF-LEADERSHIP

I describe the anxiety many students feel near graduation as "stomach rumblings" — a mix of anxiety, stress, confusion, and regret. Some of that feeling is unavoidable. But a meaningful part of it, in my experience, comes from a single unanswered question: *can I actually afford the life this degree is about to hand me?*

The diploma is the candy at the exit of the buffet. It is not enough, on its own, to keep you full. The financial math underneath it — your debt, your future income, the ratio between them — is the part almost nobody walks through with you.

Write your answer: Take your total projected student loan balance and divide by 120. That's your estimated monthly payment on a standard 10-year plan. Now subtract 25% from your expected starting salary for taxes, divide by 12. Compare the two numbers. What's the ratio?

If your loan payment is more than 10–15% of your monthly take-home, you don't have the financial freedom to be selective about your first offer — and that decision gets made before you ever see the offer letter. Better to know now than after you've signed.

What to Do With These Five Answers

You now have five honest, written answers that sit underneath your Mangle Metric score. They are not abstract — each one points directly at a dimension where action will move your number.

If you want help turning these answers into a 90-day plan, that's exactly what the live review and coaching options on andrewmangle.com are built for. But even without that step, you now have something most students never get: five specific, written answers to the questions that actually determine whether college worked.

Want a deeper read on the questions behind your score?

The full book this guide is drawn from — *The College Buffet* — is free.

andrewmangle.com/score.html

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